TRUMP MANAGEMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

TRUMP MANAGEMENT LESSON

When you play a suit contract the first, and usually most important, decision you need to make is whether to start by pulling trumps. Fortunately there is a rule for you to follow which is never wrong.

YOU SHOULD ALWAYS PULL TRUMPS IMMEDIATELY -
EXCEPT FOR THOSE TIMES WHEN YOU SHOULDN'T

This lesson and the Deals that go with it will show you those times.

Always pull trumps immediately:

The contract is 4♥ and West leads the ♠J.

♠ 7 3
♥ A J 9 4 2
♦ 9 6 4
♣ Q J 10



♠ A K Q
♥ K Q 10 5 3
♦ 8 7 3
♣ K 3

You have 3 losers in ♦s and 1 in ♣s.

You are ecstatic that West didn't lead a minor suit so you play your 3 high ♠s and discard a ♦ from dummy on the third one. Unfortunately East ruffs the ♠ and the defense takes their **2** ♦ tricks plus the ♣A.

This is a really basic example but I'll bet we have all seen it happen. Of course you should win the first trick, **THEN PULL TRUMPS**, then run the ♠s for the discard.

Too easy you say, and you are right. Probably everybody reading this would have pulled trumps.

Have you ever had someone, (your partner?), tell you that they couldn't pull trumps because the suit was too weak? Bad reasoning; with weak trumps and strong side suits you should lead trumps early and often.

The contract is 4♠ and West leads the ♣8.

♠ 7 4 3 2
♥ A K Q
♦ J 10 9
♣ K J 9



♠ 9 8 6 5
♥ J 10 9
♦ A K Q
♣ A Q 10

You have no losers in any suit except trumps.

And if the trumps split 3-2 you can HOPE to lose only 3 tricks there. So you should win the first trick and lead a trump - which you will lose. Win the next trick and play another trump - which you will lose. Win the next trick and lose one more trump if you like, it doesn't matter at this point.

But think what could happen if you didn't play on trumps at every opportunity. You could be leading high side suit cards and East ruffs a ♣ with the ♠10. Then West ruffs a ♥ with the ♠J. And East ruffs with the ♠Q, and West ruffs with the ♠K and somebody still has the ♠A. In other words the defenders had 5 high trumps and you let them make them all individually.

Point made.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you need to ruff tricks in dummy:

The contract is 6♦ and West leads the ♦5.

♠ 8 5
♥ 9 6 5 2
♦ 7 4
♣ A K 7 4 2



♠ A K 4 3
♥ A K 3
♦ A K Q J 9
♣ 5

You have 2 losers in ♠s and 1 in ♥s.
You can pull trumps, then discard the ♥ loser on dummy's high ♣, but you will still be left with the 2 ♠s.

A better play is delay pulling trumps. Play the ♠ A K 4, ruffing the ♠4 with dummy's last trump. Then play a ♥ to your hand and now pull trumps.

You will still have 1 ♠ loser at the end but you will make the contract.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you need the trump suit for entries:

The contract is 6♠ and West leads the ♣K.

♠ K Q 2
♥ 6 5 3
♦ 7 3 2
♣ 8 5 4 2



♠ A J 10 9 6 4
♥ A K
♦ A Q J
♣ A 7

With a sure ♣ loser you need to have the ♦ finesse.

Suppose trumps split 3-1 (probable) and you pull them ending in dummy. You can then take the ♦ finesse but even when it wins you are doomed because you cannot repeat it.

Instead win the first trick and play ♠A then small to dummy's ♠Q. Now finesse the ♦ successfully and return to the ♠K, pulling the last trump. Finesse the ♦ once more and claim.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you can't afford to lose the lead yet:

Perhaps the reason you can't afford to lose the lead yet is that you need to discard a loser quickly. The contract is 5♣ and West leads the ♥Q.

♠ K Q 2
♥ 6 5 3
♦ A 8
♣ Q 6 5 4 3



♠ A 4
♥ A 7 2
♦ K 5 4
♣ K J 9 8 7

The ♥ lead has exposed your 2 ♥ losers early.

You can ruff the small ♦ in dummy, but you cannot avoid losing the Ace of trumps. If you lead a ♣ now the defenders will grab their ♣A and immediately cash their 2 ♥ tricks.

So before playing a trump you play 3 ♠s, discarding a ♥ on dummy's third ♠. Only then is it safe to start pulling trumps.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you plan to play a cross-ruff:

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♦K.

♠ A
♥ Q J 9 7
♦ 9 8 7 5 3
♣ A 7 5



♠ 9 8 7 4 2
♥ A K 10 8
♦ A
♣ K 6 4

You can win your 4 side suit high cards, then alternate ruffing 4 ♠s in dummy and 4 ♦s in your hand.

One of the two keys to a cross-ruff is that you might not have enough winners if you play a round of trumps. In this deal, for example, you needed to make all 8 trumps individually; even one lead would have cost you two trumps for one winning trick.

The second key is that you must take any side-suit winners early. Here if you delay taking your ♣A and ♣K, one of the defenders might discard ♣s while you are playing the other suits and be able to ruff a ♣ winner late in the game.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you plan a dummy reversal:

A mistake made frequently by beginners is taking an early ruff in the long-trump hand. When you ruff in the short-trump hand it does two good things - it gives you an immediate winner and it also gives you an extra winner. When you ruff in the long-trump hand it gives you an immediate winner but it seldom gives you an extra trick.

Look at these three hands:

You are playing a ♥ contract and West leads the ♣ A K.

♠ K J 7 2
♥ K Q J
♦ 6 5 4 3 2
♣ 2



♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ --
♣ 5 4 3

You can ruff 2 ♣s in dummy, the short-trump hand.

You will now make a total of 7 trump tricks, your 5 plus dummy's 2 ruffs.

Dummy's ruffs have actually gained you 2 tricks.

♠ K J 7
♥ K Q J
♦ 5 4 3 2
♣ 8 6 2



♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ A 6
♣ 3

You can ruff the second ♣ in your hand, the long-trump hand.

You could even ruff dummy's last ♣ if you wanted to, but it wouldn't help you.

Because ruffing in your hand hasn't gained you any tricks, you still only get 5 trump tricks.

♠ K J
♥ K Q J
♦ 5 4 3 2
♣ 8 6 4 2



♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ A 6
♣ 3

Ruff the second ♣ in your hand with the ♥A.
Play a ♥ to dummy's ♥J.
Ruff dummy's third ♣ in your hand.
Play a ♥ to dummy's ♥Q.
Ruff dummy's last ♣ with your last ♥.
Play a ♠ to dummy's ♠K.
Pull the opponents' last trump with dummy's ♥K, discarding your ♦ loser.
Overtake dummy's ♠J and your hand is good.
You actually made 6 trump tricks, 3 ruffs in your hand, and the 3 you pulled trumps with in dummy.

This is called a Dummy Reversal - because you used dummy's hand to pull trumps with, and took the ruffs in your own hand.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . the only trump left out is the master trump:

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♠A.

♠ 7 2
♥ K 5 4
♦ A 3
♣ A K Q J 10 9



♠ --
♥ A Q 7 6 2
♦ K 9 8 4 2
♣ 4 3 2

You ruff the ♠A and start pulling trumps with the ♥K, then the ♥A. West follows with the ♥3, then discards a ♠ on the second ♥ play so you will lose a trick to East's ♥ J 10 9 8.

You continue with the ♥Q which leaves you with just the ♥7 remaining in your hand while East has the master ♥J. Should you play the final trump?

Heck no! If you did there would be no stopping the avalanche of ♠s they would play! Instead, just start running dummy's ♣s until East gets frustrated and ruffs with the ♥J. Of course that now leaves you with a trump to stop the ♠s.

Despite the above suggestion, there is a time when you do not want to leave the master trump left out - when dummy has a long suit to run but has no outside entries. Change the previous hand around.

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♠A.

♠ 7 3 2
♥ 5 4
♦ 4 3
♣ A K Q J 10 9



♠ --
♥ A K Q 7 6 2
♦ A 9 8 4 2
♣ 3 2

You ruff the ♠A and start pulling trumps with the ♥A, then the ♥K. West follows with the ♥3, then discards a ♠ on the second ♥, so you will lose a trump trick to East's ♥ J 10 9 8.

Suppose you pull just one more trump with the ♥Q, then switch to ♣s, leaving East with the master ♥J. No good. East will ruff the second or third ♣ and even though you will have trump control you won't have a way back to dummy's good ♣s.

Instead you go ahead and force Easts ♥J out with your ♥7, still leaving you with the ♥6. If East plays a ♠ you can ruff with the last trump and then run the ♣ suit uninterrupted.

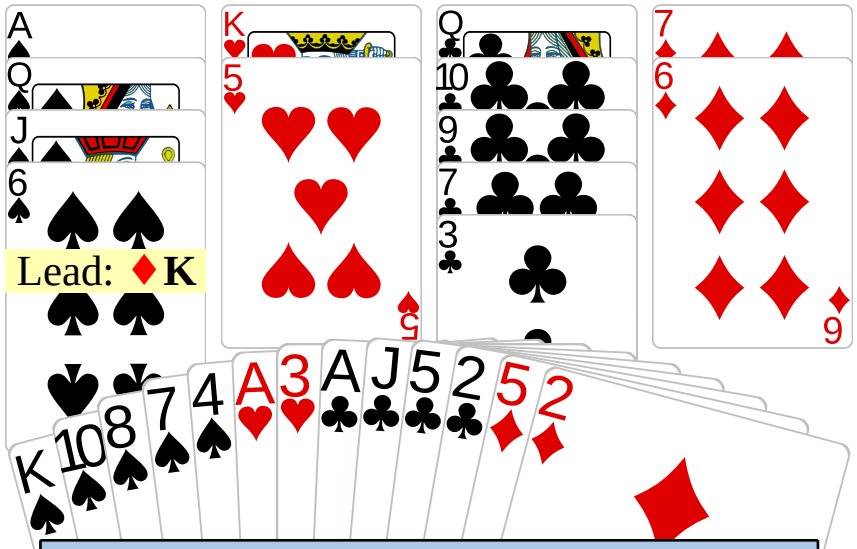
The last word:

This lesson and the practice Deals are mainly about the various times when you need to delay pulling trumps or perhaps not pull them at all. Don't let that give you the wrong idea though.

MOST OF THE TIME YOU SHOULD PULL TRUMPS IMMEDIATELY

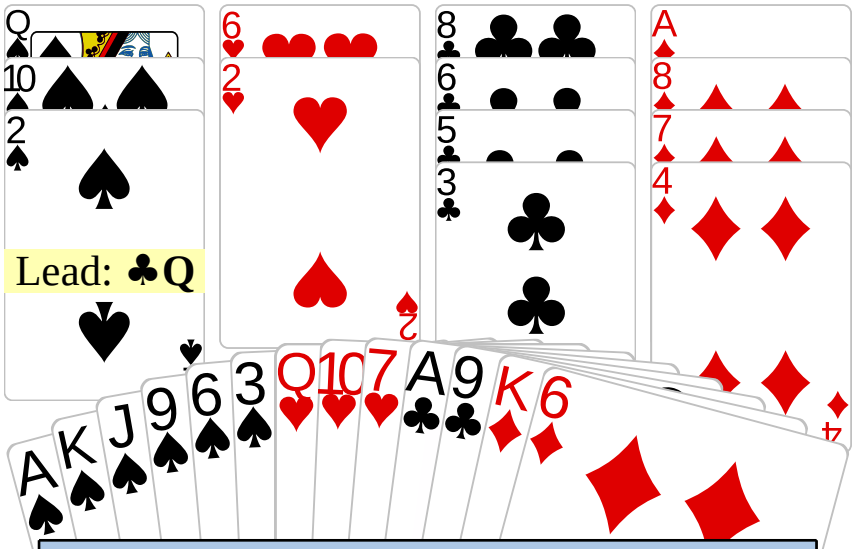
. . . 20 examples should be worth more than another 2000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



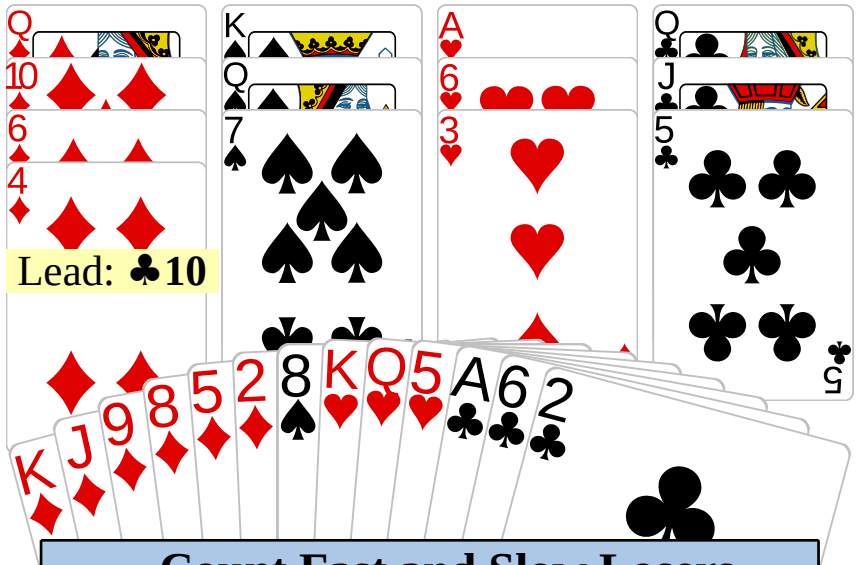
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **5♦** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦K

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥7

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 5♦
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣10

Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 10 8 7 4 ♥ A 3 ♦ 5 2 ♣ A J 5 2	
♠ 9 2 ♥ J 9 7 6 2 ♦ A 9 8 4 3 ♣ 4	N W E S	♠ 5 3 ♥ Q 10 8 4 ♦ K Q J 10 ♣ K 8 6
	♠ A Q J 6 ♥ K 5 ♦ 7 6 ♣ Q 10 9 7 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	1♠	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♦K

North is to play 4♠. East leads the ♦K. West overtakes with the ♦A and returns the ♣4.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 3

This looks like a walk in the park. If West has the ♣K you can let that ♣4 ride around to dummy and end up making 12 tricks! What could go wrong?

What could go wrong is that East could win the ♣K and return a ♣ which West ruffs. West could then play a ♦ back to East's ♦Q, who could play another ♣ which West could again ruff. You could go down 2. That's what could go wrong.

Now, what should go right. Just because the lesson had many examples where you delayed pulling trumps, it is still true that **MOST OF THE TIME** you should pull trumps immediately. And this is one of those times.

So grab your ♣A at trick 2, pull trumps no matter how many pulls it takes, then establish the ♣s. The contract is cold.

For most suit contracts the immediate pulling of trumps should be the first priority.

Clear thinking is important, too. Can you imagine any Bridge player in the West seat overtaking his partner's opening lead just so he could then underlead his ♣K into dummy's ♣Q?

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 7 ♥ A 8 5 4 3 ♦ Q 10 3 2 ♣ K 7 2	
♠ Q 10 2 ♥ 6 2 ♦ A 8 7 4 ♣ 8 6 5 3	N W E S	♠ A K J 9 6 3 ♥ Q 10 7 ♦ K 6 ♣ A 9
	♠ 8 5 4 ♥ K J 9 ♦ J 9 5 ♣ Q J 10 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	Pass	1♠	Pass
2♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♣Q

East is to play 4♠. South leads the ♣Q.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=3 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 4

You can't help the ♣ loser, but the ♥ loser can be ruffed in dummy. The most important question right now is how many rounds of trumps to pull before you give up a ♥?

You win the ♣A.

None would be the correct answer. Suppose you decide to go over to dummy with the ♠Q so as to lead a ♥ toward your ♥ Q 10 7. When South won the trick he would probably play another trump. Then when you gave up a second ♥ dummy's final trump might be removed.

Win the first trick and play a ♥ from your hand. If they play a ♠, win in your hand and play another ♥. If they play another ♠ it will be just the second and dummy will still have one ♠ left to ruff your ♥ loser.

At the first hint that you might be thinking of ruffing losers in dummy the defenders are going to start leading trumps to try to prevent you.

So you must stay a jump ahead of them. In this Deal the only way they could have gotten the jump on you would have been with a trump opening lead.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 7 3 2 ♥ A K ♦ J 8 6 4 ♣ 7 5 3	
♠ J 10 5 ♥ 9 7 ♦ 9 3 2 ♣ K J 9 6 4	N W E S	♠ A 9 6 ♥ 8 6 4 ♦ K Q 10 7 ♣ Q 10 8
	♠ K Q 4 ♥ Q J 10 5 3 2 ♦ A 5 ♣ A 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	1NT	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♥7

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♥7, won by dummy's ♥A.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

You need to find East with the ♠A to avoid two losers in the suit. But even if he has the card you must still be careful. You are in dummy right now, and you are only going to be in dummy once more.

East plays low.

Right now you must lead a ♠ toward your hand and put up the ♠K when East plays low. When this wins the trick return to dummy with a trump and play another ♠ toward the ♠Q. When this also wins you can pull trumps, not before.

It may go against the grain not to start pulling trumps immediately, but the urgency to remove the enemy trumps must be weighed against the best plan for the hand as a whole.

Here there was no realistic hope of making this contract without playing twice toward your ♠ K Q.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ J 6 5 2 ♥ 10 8 4 ♦ A 3 ♣ 10 9 8 3	
♠ 8 ♥ K Q 5 ♦ K J 9 8 5 2 ♣ A 6 2		♠ K Q 7 ♥ A 6 3 ♦ Q 10 6 4 ♣ Q J 5
	♠ A 10 9 4 3 ♥ J 9 7 2 ♦ 7 ♣ K 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♦	Pass	2NT	Pass
3♦	Pass	5♦	
All Pass			

5♦ by West
Lead: ♣10

West is to play 5♦. North leads the ♣10. You play dummy's ♣J and South puts on the ♣K; you win the ♣A.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 3

The ♠ loser and ♦ loser are "fast" losers, meaning your opponents can take them whenever they are in the lead. The ♣ loser is a "slow" loser, meaning you might have some time to dispose of it.

But here is the problem. If you start to draw trumps, a defender will take the ♦A and play another ♣, forcing out your ♣Q. Then, when you play a ♠ they will jump in with the ♠A and take their ♣ trick. Anything you can think of to do about that?

North plays low.

Once you recognize the problem, the solution is easier to see. Don't play trumps next!

Instead, win the first trick and immediately play your ♠ toward dummy's ♠ K Q. A defender will probably take this trick but you don't care. They will play another ♣ to try to set up a trick in the suit but you can win the ♣, enter dummy with the ♥A, and discard your "slow" ♣ loser on dummy's good ♠ honor.

And then, with that important job done, you can lead trumps.

Bridge is a game of timing, and sometimes the tempo of the game is set by the opening lead.

Suppose North's opening lead was a ♠, a ♥ or a ♦. You would have still had the same 3 losers, but now the ♣ loser would have been "very slow". So slow that you could start on trumps before working on the ♠s.

In other words, with one of these opening leads a mediocre player, one who had never read this lesson, would probably make the contract without any trouble. But with the ♣ lead only a skilled declarer would make it!